

T **HREE TITANS. THREE** different paths to the top. Tata Sons Chairman N. Chandrasekaran, who holds a Masters in Computer Application (MCA), never went to a B-school. World Bank Group President Ajay Banga is one of the most illustrious alumni to walk out of IIM Ahmedabad (IIMA). And Indira Nooyi topped up her IIM Calcutta (IIMC) MBA with a Masters in Management from Yale before landing her career-defining role at PepsiCo. “A good leader comes in so many shapes and sizes that the leader at the top could come from any background,” says SPJIMR Dean Varun Nagaraj. In fact, XLRI Jamshedpur Director Fr S. George says the presence of an MBA does not always guarantee superior leadership or company performance. “Entrepreneurial CEOs such as Bill Gates and Steve Jobs have demonstrated that the lack of an MBA degree does not hinder success,” he says. “Many CEOs have reached their current positions by either starting their own companies or climbing the ladder without an MBA.”

94 | He may be on to something. Consider this snapshot of corporate zeitgeist. Research by *Business Today* shows that more than 60 per cent of the ex-

ecutive heads (Chairpersons or Managing Directors or CEOs) of the current Top 50 Indian companies by market capitalisation do not have a management degree. A lot of them are engineers and CAs. But, intriguingly, of 29 top global CEOs of Indian origin that *BT* looked at, most acquired an international MBA degree before attaining worldwide prominence. And not one of them has done an MBA from India. “In India, CEOs at the top today have risen up the corporate ladder having largely worked in an era of limited resources and licence *raj* when *jugaad* [innovation] was the way of doing business and achieving success,” says Ramabhadran Thirumalai, Deputy Dean–Academic Programmes at ISB.

“Our B-schools are 50 years old. Theirs are 100–150 years old. [In India] you will find a lot of MBA holders in COO/CFO/CMO or [country manager] positions,” says Suresh K. Jakhar, Chairperson, PGP, and Associate Professor at IIM Lucknow (IIML). “A level below (the CEO) at C-1 is where structure plays a role, and management discipline is required more so. That’s probably why you’re seeing MBAs in those roles,” says Nagaraj, adding that it’s more a reflection of leadership at the highest level involving far too many variables.

There are many more ways to argue in favour of Indian schools. India has many family businesses with their own internal training systems. The IIT-IIM managers have favoured tech-oriented companies, while

Progress Report



A majority of the 3,000-plus B-schools in India fall short of being aspirational for students, despite the country being home to several prestigious management education institutes



Only four Indian institutes—IIMA, IIMB, IIMC and ISB (Hyderabad and Mohali)—rank in the Top 100 in the list of top B-schools compiled by QS World University Rankings–Full Time MBA: Global 2023, with the top Indian school, IIMA, ranked 44



Roadblocks in accreditation, diversity quotient, world-class faculty and funding are some of the major challenges Indian B-schools have to navigate



Meanwhile, international MBAs, although expensive, open up global career trajectories for students

The Triple Crown

1

The Triple Crown or Triple Accreditation in management education refers to business schools certified by three major bodies: The Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB), the Association of MBAs (AMBA), and EFMD Quality Improvement System (EQUIS)

2

Only 24 participants of *BT*'s ranking of two-year programmes in India have at least one international accreditation; only IIM Calcutta and IIM Indore are Triple Crown holders

3

18 of them have the AACSE, 11 have AMBA and only four—IIMC, IIMI, IIMA, IIMB—have EQUIS